

edge to bear upon your investment program, you may well find that you have done worse." This from Mr. Graham.

21. "If things aren't clear, do nothing"—Mr. Loeb.

22. "Nothing is more suicidal than a rational investment policy in an irrational world." This direct from Mr. Keynes.

No doubt you've come across some or all of the above rules of investing in newspapers and business magazines, where they are frequently repeated, though not always side by side. Reading them one after another, I was struck by the unusual tolerance we have for differences of opinion on matters of money. I tried to think of another subject, art or science, where the guiding principles contradict one another so completely and yet are simultaneously held in equal esteem by the same audience. Only in diet and health-food books is there anything remotely similar. Buyers of diet books can tolerate one contradictory scientific theory after another while failing to lose weight, and perhaps the same can be said for consumers of investment advice who have yet to see a profit.

Was there not a single principle on which the Wall Street experts could agree in print? Actually, I found only one: the average investor is always wrong. It was surprising to see this so openly admitted in the very books that offer us their help! Mr. Tobias, for instance, hardly waits a single page to announce that most people are the last ones in on a stock deal, and it's the 95 percent that enrich the other five, and so on. Then in the 200 pages that follow, he advises us 95-percenters how to go out and buy stocks! In between giving his suggestions, Mr. Loeb takes time out to declare the average investor a hopeless case. He even recommends his favorite book—*Extraordinary Popular Delusions and the Madness of Crowds*, written by MacKay in 1841—as proof that the masses are eternally misguided. In the introduction to an investment system he is trying to popularize, Benjamin Graham blurts